



NARRATIVE REPORT FOR OCTOBER 2025

INTRODUCTION

October was a month of renewed momentum for Kenya Keys as we continued supporting bright and deserving students across the region. A key highlight was the visit from our U.S. Operations Director, whose presence strengthened collaboration and offered valuable learning for the team.

Throughout the month, we carried out a range of impactful activities, including food distribution in schools, Bahakwenu women group house renovation, updating student data in Airtable, and supporting learners as secondary schools closed for the term. We also held the 3rd Term Conference, celebrated student graduations, and enriched our library with donated books and a visit from a local publisher. Students continued to benefit from psychosocial support, health talks, and mentorship sessions.

We remain grateful for the steadfast support of our donors, whose generosity makes these achievements possible. The progress made in October reflects the meaningful impact of your partnership. Below is the special highlight of some of October activities.

1. China visit

During the month of October, we were fortunate to host our US Operations Manager, China, for several days. China is a remarkably kind, patient, and knowledgeable leader, and her presence brought tremendous value to our entire team.

Throughout her visit, staff members had the opportunity to learn from her in a wide range of areas from using Airtable more effectively to navigating QuickBooks Online and many other essential operational skills. Her willingness to share her expertise and guide us through practical learning sessions left a lasting impact on our daily work.

China also took time to interact with every department, listening, asking thoughtful questions, and engaging in meaningful discussions that helped strengthen our systems and teamwork. Beyond the office, she joined us in outdoor activities, creating space for deeper connections and shared experiences.

Kenya Keys remains deeply grateful for the opportunity to host her. Her visit not only enhanced our skills but also inspired us with new ideas and renewed energy. We appreciate her dedication, her warmth, and the invaluable knowledge she shared with us.



A moment of learning and connection as China interacts with our team

2. Food aid distribution

As students across the country prepared to sit for their national assessments and examinations, many schools faced a silent but urgent crisis- a lack of food. For a student struggling to concentrate through hunger, even the brightest mind can dim, and examination performance becomes severely affected. Many students, especially those from vulnerable households, often go for days with little or no food during normal school days. It is within this reality that Kenya Keys stepped in, offering timely food support to schools to ensure that students could sit for their examinations with strength, dignity, and peace of mind.

This vital donation reached 17 institutions: 9 primary schools, six high schools, and one children's home. The food was distributed immediately before the examination week to help schools create a stable environment where learners could focus fully on their exams without worrying about meals. The provision of maize, maize flour, wheat flour (for selected schools), cooking oil, rice, beans, and sugar ensured that schools could provide consistent meals throughout the exam period. The children's home was included to support the increased number of children returning from school for the long holiday. For both schools and students, this intervention brought relief amid tough economic challenges and contributed greatly to improved concentration, reduced anxiety, and better readiness for the examinations.

Thanks to the generous support of our sponsors, that made all this possible. Your support did far more than fill stomachs. It gave children the strength to face their exams with clear minds. It gave them dignity when they would have otherwise sat for hours hungry and anxious. It gave them a sense of being seen, valued, and supported, especially those who left home with nothing to eat and no guarantee of when their next meal would come.

For many of these students, your help turned what could have been a painful, discouraging experience into one filled with hope and possibility. Teachers shared stories of learners who, for the first time in days, could concentrate fully; students who whispered "thank you" as they received their meals; and entire classrooms where confidence replaced worry.

Your kindness reached far beyond the exam rooms. You invested in students who are fighting every day for a better future, despite hardships most people never speak of- you reminded them that they are not alone.

We offer our deepest and most sincere gratitude to each of you. Your compassion changed lives during this exam period, and its impact will continue to echo in the futures of these young Learners.



Thanks to you, Mackinnon Girls and Taru boys students went into exams confident and were ready to shine.



Joyful and lively! the Children's Home and Mgalani High after your generous support.



Fuleye students living the joy of giving and sharing.

3. Bahakwenu women group house renovation

Bahakwenu Women Group holds a special place in the history of Kenya Keys. They were the first beneficiaries of an infrastructure project built by Kenya Keys in 2008 a building that has continued to serve as an important space for women's empowerment and community development. The facility was officially opened that same year by Mama Rinda, the co-founder of Kenya Keys. In October, the building received a full renovation funded by generous sponsors, restoring and strengthening a structure that has supported the group for many years.

We extend our sincere appreciation to the sponsors whose commitment and generosity made this renovation possible. Their support has not only preserved an important part of Kenya Keys' history but has also provided the Bahakwenu community with a renewed and functional space that will continue to uplift local families.

The renovated house will have a significant impact on the Bahakwenu community. It will offer women a safe and organized environment where they can meet, run income-generating activities, participate in training sessions, and support one another. The space will also serve as a hub for community engagement, promoting unity, learning, and long-term development.

Bahakwenu Village remains a place of cherished memories for Kenya Keys, as it is at Bahakwenu Primary School where the organization first began its work. This renovation honors that history and reinforces the strong, lasting partnership between Kenya Keys and the community.



Bahakwenu women group house as it was, awaiting transformation.





The historic Bahakwenu women group house, Kenya Keys' first construction project, restored to serve community once again.

Alongside the above special highlights, the month also featured a range of impactful departmental activities as listed below:

SPONSORSHIP DEPARTMENT

The month of October was quite eventful. From preparing to receive a member of staff from the United States to serving community members who frequently contact the office for support on matters surrounding education and development, be it intervention for students sent out of school, inquiries about previous applications, or new sponsorship requests, the Sponsorship Department remained dedicated to ensuring that students stay in school and continue building the skills necessary to become successful members of society. Below are the impactful activities that were carried out within the month by the department:

1. Student Bios

As the year draws to a close, the department entered its busiest season, processing numerous applications from new students, particularly those transitioning from Grade 9 to Grade 10 under Kenya's Competency-Based Curriculum (CBC).

To manage this influx efficiently, the team collaborated with the U.S. Sponsorship Director to create an updated bio form. The new questionnaire simplifies data collection and ensures smooth onboarding for new students.

2. Airtable Updates

With several of our university students graduating in October, the sponsorship team updated their records and status in Airtable. This timely update made it easier to identify the new graduates and support them in preparing appreciation letters for their sponsors.

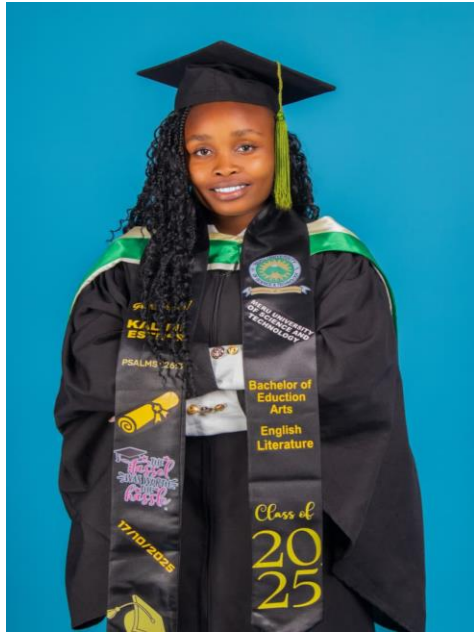
We extend our heartfelt gratitude to the sponsors who walked with these students throughout their academic journey. Your consistent support did more than pay tuition-it unlocked potential, opened doors, and empowered young people to achieve dreams that once felt out of reach.

Because of your generosity, these graduates can now step confidently into the next chapter of their lives, equipped with skills, knowledge, and hope for a brighter future. Your sponsorship has truly transformed lives, and we remain deeply grateful.



With Rory and Cindy Reid's support lighting the way, Prisca Nzadze Nguta dances across the finish line of her bachelor's in political science, and the Class of 2025 celebrates every sparkling step.

You turn every smile of the Class of 2025 into a story of brighter futures! Thank you.



In the Brilliant Class of 2025, Esther Kalimi Nzisa steps forward with her Degree in Education, her journey beautifully lifted by the generosity of Dave and Clare Petersen.

The smiles of the Class of 2025 reflect your kindness and the brighter futures you make possible! Thank you.

3. Secondary schools closing for holiday

Secondary schools officially closed for the long holiday, and students visited the office to submit their report forms and fee structures. This process allowed the department to confirm each student's safe return home and provided an opportunity for one-on-one guidance based on their academic performance. These conversations helped encourage students, address challenges, and prepare them for the next term.

During their visit, the students also expressed heartfelt gratitude for the support they have received throughout the year. Many shared how this assistance not only helped them continue their studies but also gave them hope, confidence, and the motivation to dream bigger. Their words reflected genuine appreciation for the care and opportunities that have made it possible for them to overcome challenges and keep moving forward.



Students mark closing day with joy, reflection, and hope



A report form goes in, and your impact shines through.

4. College and University students update

a. University students

The month was challenging for university students as lecturers went on strike due to unpaid lecturers' salaries. The strike persisted throughout October, forcing students to remain idle in school before eventually returning home.

b. College students

College, TTC, and vocational students continued their studies smoothly, with many completing their semesters or proceeding on attachment. KMTC students were stationed across the country. Several college students visited the office to submit term reports and fill out fee request forms, an appreciated gesture that facilitates effective monitoring and timely budgeting.



Each form filled and handed in is a small but powerful testament to the hope our donors create.

(c) Sponsorship applications

The flow of sponsorship applications never slows. Even when there are no vacancies, the persistence of students and families speaks volumes about the transformative hope sponsorship represents.

The department is looking forward to receiving more applications, especially for grade 10 students, eager, determined young students ready to advance their education and unlock their full potential.

5. Secondary school students' conference

Thanks to our wonderful sponsors, the 3rd Term Students' Conference on 29th October was a remarkable gathering of students, parents, teachers, and facilitators-full of mentorship, guidance, and celebration of student growth.

A key highlight of the conference was the participation of all Kenya Keys departments, each of which addressed students and parents on various important topics. These sessions covered academic expectations, character development, mental health awareness, student welfare, and parental involvement.

Their presentations offered clarity, direction, and encouragement, creating a well-rounded learning experience. The day was filled with educational talks and mentorship that inspired students to reflect on their progress, take responsibility for their choices, and strive for excellence.

Students benefited greatly from structured mentorship sessions, where they were guided on academic planning, personal discipline, and setting realistic goals for the next term. Open discussions on mental health helped students understand the importance of emotional wellbeing and provided them with

practical strategies for managing stress and seeking support. Parents were also updated on their obligations and the critical role they play in reinforcing positive behavior and supporting academic performance at home. Personalized one-on-one sessions offered a safe space for addressing individual challenges and monitoring student progress.



Students at the CEC Hall embracing every lesson with excitement



From attentive listening with parents to memorable moments with our moderators outside, a day full of learning and inspiration.

LIBRARY DEPARTMENT

October was a season of learning, connection, and growth for the Library Department. It was a vibrant month filled with enriching activities, productive partnerships, and moments of reflection. The Department continued to nurture a culture of reading, curiosity, and collaboration-all aimed at improving access to information and empowering our learners and community members. The spirit of curiosity and community shone brightly as students, staff, and visitors came together to make the library not just a place of books, but a vibrant hub of ideas and transformation. From visits by partners to special programs for learners, October was a month filled with inspiring activities that strengthened our mission to promote education and lifelong learning.

Here are some of the highlights that made October truly special:

1. Visit by publishers

This month, the library department was honored to receive visits from Moran (EA) publishers and Longhorn publishers, both of whom made significant contributions to the resource development efforts.

- ❖ Moran publishers provided us with a new library catalogue, an essential tool that will help in streamlining collection and improving the accessibility of materials.
- ❖ Longhorn publishers brought rationalized competency-based curriculum (CBC) books, ensuring the learning materials remain current and aligned with national education standards. They brought a total of 24 books.

These visits not only strengthened our partnership with publishers but also affirmed our shared commitment to supporting learners through quality educational materials.

2. October inventory

During this period the Department received a bunch of books brought by China and we express our sincere appreciation to our donors for their generous donation of books to the Department. These materials will greatly enrich our collection and provide valuable resources for both students and the wider community. The books will support academic learning, research, and personal development, helping to cultivate a stronger reading culture and a more informed society.



Endless possibilities unfold as your kindness inspires young minds to explore, learn, and grow.

3. Library service desk

Serving as the central hub, the library service desk offered personalized assistance, from research guidance to borrowing support, ensuring every visitor could access and benefit from library resources with ease.

Through the service desk, users were able to:

- ❖ Make inquiries about available books, library policies, and borrowing procedures.
- ❖ Consult with library staff on research topics, book recommendations, and effective use of reference materials.
- ❖ Receiving guidance on locating materials within the library and navigating different library sections.

The library service desk ensured visitors felt welcomed and supported, fostering both learning and exploration while keeping communication between the team and users smooth and effective.

4. Book title search

Comprehensive book title search was done in preparation of future order placement. This involved checking and verifying book titles, authors, editions, and publication details against the library's existing catalog. Through this exercise, the department identified the specific textbooks and learning materials needed to effectively implement the new syllabus.

We express our sincere gratitude to all donors, organizations, and partners who have already supported us through book donations. Your contributions have greatly helped to improve access to learning materials and have positively impacted on the quality of education in schools and our Taru community library.

The department is still in need of more books, especially Grade 10 books. Access to these books is critical to ensure that students can follow the new curriculum effectively and that no learner is left behind due to lack of resources.

We therefore appeal to partners, stakeholders, and well-wishers to continue supporting this initiative by donating Grade 10 books as identified in the title search. Your ongoing generosity will directly contribute to better learning outcomes and a brighter future for our students.

We sincerely appreciate your continued support and commitment to education. Together, we can make a lasting difference.

5. Evening reading and game- playing sessions

During the month of October, the evening reading and game playing sessions continued to bring energy, learning, and connection to the library. These sessions offered a calm and friendly environment for both academic and recreational engagement. The reading sessions provided a valuable opportunity for learners of all levels. This program also incorporated educational and recreational game-playing sessions such as word puzzles and educational quizzes aimed at enhancing learners' vocabulary, spelling, problem-solving skills and strategic thinking. The games encouraged teamwork, patience, and healthy competition, while helping participants apply what they learn in a fun and practical way. Overall, the October reading and game playing sessions strengthened the library's role as a holistic learning hub where education meets enjoyment, and where every learner feels supported in their journey towards success.



Students making the most of evening reading and playtime.

6. Library statistics

This month of October recorded steady and encouraging growth in library usage, reflecting the community's increasing commitment to reading and academic excellence. The library continued to serve as a vital center for learning, information access, and personal development.

Total no. of visitors-305

Book borrowed - 49

Books returned - 38

Books renewed - 11

Key highlights:

- ❖ User engagement: the consistent rise in library visits and borrowing demonstrates growing trust in library services and a strengthened reading culture within the community.
- ❖ ServiceDesk efficiency: the high number of consultations shows the active interaction between staff and users, improving access to relevant materials and information.

7. Non-Formal Education Program (NFE)

(i) China Visit to Non-Formal Education Program (NFE)

China visited the non-formal education program supported by Kenya Keys. The purpose of their visit was to gain a deeper understanding of how the program operates and the impact it has on the community. The non-formal education program supports disadvantaged adults who were unable to afford formal schooling.

The students expressed heartfelt appreciation to the sponsors whose support has enabled them to continue their education and pursue new opportunities. They also shared deep gratitude for their teachers, whose commitment and encouragement have played a vital role in their academic journey. The appreciation shown by the learners highlighted the transformative impact that Kenya Keys, its partners, and the educators have had in empowering adults and giving them renewed hope for their futures.



Passion for learning brings people together-China with NFE Learners and teachers

(ii) NFE Practicals held at Taru Boys.

Non-formal education practicals were held at Taru Boys, giving students an important opportunity to prepare as exam days approached. The hands-on sessions were crucial for the candidates, as they allowed learners to apply theoretical knowledge in a practical setting, build confidence, and develop problem-solving skills essential for their exams. During the lessons, students also demonstrated creativity and teamwork, making the learning process both engaging and effective.

We extend heartfelt appreciation to the sponsors whose support made these practical sessions possible. Their contribution continues to empower learners and enhance the quality of education offered through the non-formal program.



Your support turns practice into power, Immense thanks to our sponsors.

(iii) 2025 NFE candidates meeting

We held the meeting with Non-Formal Education (NFE) candidates ahead of their national exams in Kwale at our CEC Hall. The session aimed to encourage, motivate, and build confidence in the students as they prepared for this important milestone.

Kenya Keys staff were present to inspire and guide the learners. Thanks to our generous sponsors, these students got a second chance to pursue their dreams, something many once thought was beyond their reach. On the same day, they also received upkeep allowances to support them during the exam period.

Through your support, not only is potential unlocked, but hope and confidence are also restored. The students left motivated, encouraged, and ready to excel in their exams.

Thank you to our sponsors for making this life-changing opportunity possible!



With every smile and step forward, our NFE students reflect the power of your generosity and the guidance of their amazing team.

GENDER AND AFFIRMATIVE ACTION DEPARTMENT

The Department continues to play a vital role in promoting gender equity, student welfare, and inclusive education within partner schools and communities. Its mandate focuses on empowering girls and young women through mentorship, health education, safety programs, and targeted support aimed at enhancing academic participation and retention.

During the month of October, the Department implemented a range of activities and interventions designed to address the social, academic, and personal development needs of students. These included a comprehensive health talk session at Nyari Primary School, ongoing implementation of the Usalama Program for secondary learners, the Vital Student Support Program for post-secondary learners, students conference and monitoring of the TechLit Program in collaboration with TechLit Africa.

This report provides a summary of the key activities undertaken, the outcomes achieved, and emerging challenges observed during the reporting period.

1. Usalama Program

The Usalama Program, a core initiative under Kenya Keys, focuses on promoting student safety and well-being both in schools and within their home environments.

In October, the department received 40 complete kits from a Kenya Keys staff member visiting from the USA. The GAA team assembled additional washable sanitary kits using locally available materials, bringing the total to 150 complete kits. These kits were distributed to 100 girls during Nyari Primary school health talk session, and the remaining 50 kits were donated to Sport Connect CBO, who then distributed them to girls at Nyango Primary School during a mentorship session aimed at addressing menstrual poverty and improving girls' school attendance.

Additionally, the GAA team handled several Usalama cases involving student welfare needs, such as requests for learning materials (ream paper), shopping support for the form four students who were sitting for their final exams, and in one case, emergency food assistance. In total, the department managed 29 cases this month, including 2 non-Kenya Keys students.



Every hygiene kit assembled here by G.A.A Team carries care, hope, and your generosity to the community.



With every act of kindness, a student's day brightens, essentials in hand and hope in heart.



With every kit delivered to CEO Sport Connect CBO, Nyango school girls receive dignity and confidence.



A student's day was filled with joy and smiles thanks to holiday support.

2. Vital student support program

The Vital Student Support Program serves post-secondary school students by providing assistance with transportation, upkeep, accommodation, and emergency medical needs while in college or vocational institutions.

During this month, the department handled 45 VSS cases. A notable case involved a recent graduate facing severe family challenges. Both parents are chronically ill, the mother with high blood pressure and arthritis, and the father with diabetes. Through the support of the program and a dedicated sponsor, the organization facilitated the family's registration under the Social Health Authority, ensuring access to medical care for a full year. This intervention has provided the student with stability and peace of mind as she awaits her exam results and seeks employment.

Overall, this program has continued to improve student retention, enhance performance, and build self-confidence among beneficiaries, enabling them to pursue their educational and professional aspirations.



Reaching out with care. A home visit to support a VSS special case

3. Health Talk

The GAA team conducted a health and mentorship session at Nyari Primary School, engaging 100 girls from upper primary classes. The session addressed two key themes: personal hygiene and academic empowerment.

Under the academic component, the team emphasized the importance of setting goals, building positive friendships, prioritizing education, and maintaining discipline as a key value for success. Students were encouraged to uphold personal boundaries and confidently decline influences that could derail their academic focus. The discussion concluded with an inspiring message from one of the visiting USA staff members: *“For us to be better, everyone has to do better.”*

The hygiene session involved a practical demonstration on the use, cleaning, and storage of washable sanitary towels. The facilitators stressed that liners should never be shared to prevent infections. The team also covered best practices for washing and drying undergarments and safe shaving methods to prevent skin irritation and infections.

The day concluded with the distribution of 100 hygiene kits to all participating girls.



Promoting wellness. Nyari Primary Health Talk in action.

4. TechLit Program

The TechLit Program, implemented in partnership with TechLit Africa, aims to enhance digital literacy and technological exposure among primary school learners.

In October, a new TechLit class was launched at Fuleye Primary School, joining four other active partner schools. The existing schools reported excellent progress, with learners successfully completing innovative digital projects and several students earning recognition for outstanding performance in technology-based competitions.

The GAA team, accompanied by a visiting USA staff member, visited Fuleye Primary to monitor implementation and engage with the educator and headteacher. The visit confirmed that the program is operating effectively, though two challenges were noted:

- Power Supply: The school relies on a generator for charging digital devices every two days, which increases operational costs.
- Infrastructure: Partial roof repairs have been completed, but several iron sheets still require replacement to ensure a safe and conducive learning environment.



Technology explored, potential unlocked, thanks given. Fuleye learners continue to grow.

MENTORSHIP DEPARTMENT

Bridging hearts and minds, the Mentorship Department made October unforgettable. Students gained guidance, incentives, and virtual support, while mentors extended their reach into the community. Confidence soared, discipline improved, and the ripple effect of mentorship could be felt across the organization and beyond.

1. Mentorship

For many young learners, education is a daily journey of overcoming uncertainty, pressure, and challenges. To these students, mentorship is more than a learning session; it is a pillar of strength in a student's academic path.

During the month of October, mentorship sessions were carried out for HopeSprings students across the nine service area schools. Using a structured curriculum, students were taught decision-making. This topic holds a central place in the curriculum, equipping students with practical skills to help them make thoughtful and responsible choices. Many of these students face economic and social difficulties and the pressures that come with adolescence. Learning how to choose wisely plays a key role in supporting their academic success, encouraging discipline, and helping them avoid disruptive influences, including early relationships and habits that may derail their goals.

Mentors teach students decision-making skills and build a strong foundation for long-term success. Students not only gain clarity and confidence in their daily choices, but they also develop resilience, self-awareness, and a sense of responsibility. These life-long values empower them to stay focused on their studies, remain guided by their ambitions, and shape a future that rises above present challenges.



Every Mgalani Primary student carries the spark of your generosity, turning mentorship into courage, curiosity, and change.

2. Incentive Distribution

For many students, the pursuit of education is filled with battles, the struggle to stay in class while lacking even the most basic personal items. Especially girls, the lack of sanitary towels means missing several days

of learning each month, falling behind, and battling shame that no child should ever endure. It is within these realities that small acts of care make an extraordinary difference.

Incentive distribution was carried out during the first two weeks of the month. Each boy received a packet of laundry soap, while each girl received both laundry soap and sanitary towels. These essential items, though simple, carry deep meaning. They restore dignity, promote hygiene, and allow students to focus on learning without distraction. For girls, access to sanitary towels ensures they remain comfortable and confident during menstruation, preventing absenteeism and reducing the risk of resorting to unsafe alternatives such as rags. The soap encourages personal cleanliness and eases the burden on families already strained by economic challenges, allowing parents to focus their limited resources on other important needs like school levies or meals.

Beyond hygiene, these incentives serve as a strong motivator, a tangible reminder that someone cares, that their efforts are noticed, and that education is worth pursuing. They also complement the mentorship sessions by reinforcing the message of self-care, discipline, and responsibility, fostering holistic growth among the students.

In addition to this activity, mentors also ensured that Kenya Keys-sponsored students across various schools were being followed up and supported in their academic and personal well-being.



Every item received is a reminder that someone believes in their growth.

3. Virtual Student check-in session

Consistent follow-up with students is a vital step in ensuring that they remain comfortable, focused, and emotionally supported throughout their academic journey. Adjusting to a new environment, managing

independence, and facing academic pressure can be overwhelming, and such moments call for timely guidance.

On the 15th of October, a successful online student check-in session was organized by Mr. James, who also serves as the class teacher for the group that joined universities and colleges in September. The meeting created an important space to connect with the students, understand their psychosocial well-being, and address emerging challenges. Among the key discussions were the effects of the ongoing lecturers' strike, a refresher on Kenya Keys' policies, financial management mentorship, and an open interaction segment that allowed students to share experiences.

Being the first session of its kind, this initiative marked a meaningful step toward embracing digital platforms for mentorship and support. It enabled students from different parts of the country to come together virtually, share insights, and strengthen their sense of belonging to the Kenya Keys family.

Beyond these engagements, mentors remained actively involved in broader organizational efforts that strengthened program delivery and supported overall operations.

Conclusion

October was a month of meaningful progress and strengthened connections for Kenya Keys. The commitment of our team, combined with the unwavering support of our donors, continues to drive our mission forward and create lasting impact in the lives of our students. We are grateful for every partner who walks this journey with us and remains dedicated to unlocking opportunities for bright, deserving learners. As we move into the coming months, we look forward to building on this momentum and continuing to empower students, families, and communities through education.

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